



HUMANITAS
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Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Petra Christian Academy
School Website: <https://petrachristian.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Petra Christian Academy (Boise, ID, 83713) presents itself publicly as a tuition-free, Christian classical school that emphasizes Christian formation and a classical branding. Public materials explicitly label the school as "Tuition Free Classical Education" and "Live Online Christian Classical Education," signaling a classical framework paired with a Christian worldview. The school also advertises a Statement of Faith (We believe the Bible to be the only inerrant, authoritative Word of God) and a mission to develop Christian leaders, suggesting a purpose-oriented focus on character and virtue within a theological frame. Evidence from the site includes explicit mentions of "Christian education," "classical education," and a vision of formation (e.g., formation of Christian leaders) alongside a substantial reliance on volunteer teachers to support tuition-free options. These signals point to a Classical/Christian integration, but with limited explicit articulation of several traditional classical curriculum and pedagogy elements (e.g., Great Books, Great Conversation, seven liberal arts, or structured Socratic pedagogy) in the public-facing materials. Overall assessment: **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**, with clear strengths in religious/theological grounding and formation-oriented aims, but lacking explicit, comprehensive public articulation of core classical curriculum and pedagogy markers.

Key public signals observed from Petra's materials: - Explicit classical Christian branding and online delivery: "Live Online Christian Classical Education" and "Tuition Free Classical Education." - Clear theological anchor via a Statement of Faith: "We believe the Bible to be the only inerrant, authoritative Word of God." - Admissions language framing a vision of forming Christian leaders in a Christian life. - Prominent reference to "classical Christian education" and a philosophy of thinking and well-rounded graduates. - Provision of tuition-free options and volunteer-driven teaching as a model for accessibility.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- Statement of Faith anchors theology with a Bible-centric claim: "We believe the Bible to be the only inerrant, authoritative Word of God."
- Branding emphasizes "Christian education" and "classical Christian education," signaling an integrated religious/metaphysical frame.
- Public materials describe a Christ-centered, faith-based educational approach (e.g., "Christ-centered small class sizes").
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: Christian, Bible, Word of God, theology, Christian worldview, classical Christian education.

- Negative keywords: None clearly evident in public materials (no explicit secular or value-neutral framing).
- Quantitative note: Positive keyword signal present in multiple places (roughly 4–5 distinct positive terms identified across the material), with no direct negative keyword signals detected in the public content.
- Why this rating
- The presence of a formal Statement of Faith and explicit Christian framing supports a Classical/Religious metaphysical foundation. However, the materials do not consistently showcase the full spectrum of liturgical practices or explicit metaphysical/deontological language across the cathedral of offerings; the evidence is strong on theology but lighter on the ritualistic/communal liturgical dimension. This yields a CLASSICAL-yet-limited portrayal, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- A stated vision to develop Christian leaders who influence the world through their Christian life.
- A public claim that classical Christian education is superior in track record and that the school aims at formation rather than mere information.
- General claim about forming graduates who think, learn, and grow within a Christian framework.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: formation, truth/virtue (implied by formation and leadership language), classical education, graduates, Christian life.
- Negative keywords: None detected.
- Quantitative note: Several category-relevant signals (formation, leadership, classical-education branding) appear, but explicit listing of the transcendental triad (truth, goodness, beauty) or explicit articulation of virtue formation in the public text is less direct. Estimated signal: 2–3 positive indicators, 0 negative.
- Why this rating
- The school emphasizes formation and virtue through a Christian lens (leadership, Christian life), aligning with the classical aim of shaping character. However, explicit, precise statements about cultivating virtue and wisdom as transcendental goods, beyond general formation language, are not consistently explicit in the public text. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than a clear CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site brands itself as “Classical Education” and references a classical approach, including references to “classical education” in admissions and program descriptions.
- Content mentions Christian classical education and a focus on thinking and well-rounded graduates.
- Curriculum specifics (e.g., Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium) are not clearly spelled out in the public-facing materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: classical education, Christian education, graduates, thinking.
- Negative keywords: Not clearly present in public content; however, absence of explicit Great Books/-Seven Liberal Arts language weakens the categorization.

- Quantitative note: 1–2 distinct classical-curriculum signals present; 0 explicit traditional liberal-arts terms; no negative signals detected.
- Why this rating
- Petra’s materials clearly position the school within a “classical Christian education” frame, but the public content does not explicitly enumerate the core curriculum elements (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, Trivium/Quadrivium) that define a robust classical curriculum in the rubric. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials lack explicit statements of key classical pedagogical methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, Scholé, memorization/recitation, or disciplined dialectic as primary modes in upper grades). The site emphasizes tuition-free classical branding and leadership formation rather than a pedagogy manifest in classroom practice. The explicit “Socratic” or “Scholé” language is not seen in the displayed public content.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords (from the Six Elements list) such as Socratic dialogue, Scholé, and memorization/recitation are not clearly present in Petra’s public descriptions.
- Negative keywords (e.g., “Lack of Scholé” or “lack of contemplative practice”) are not explicitly stated, but the absence of concrete pedagogical methods in the public text weighs against a classical pedagogy claim.
- Quantitative note: 0–1 clear positive pedagogy terms; 0 negative signals; effectively zero explicit classical pedagogy signals in public content.
- Why this rating
- Without explicit articulation of the classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, disciplined recitation, or Scholé-based pacing), the public-facing materials do not clearly demonstrate a classical pedagogy. Therefore Element 4 is NOT CLASSICAL in this assessment.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site advertises hiring teachers for 2024–2025, and explicitly notes volunteer-teacher models to enable tuition-free options, indicating engagement with faculty beyond a standard tuition model.
- The presence of a stated “Statement of Faith” and the emphasis on Christian formation suggest an expectation that faculty model virtue in service of the school’s aims.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: teachers, mentors, faculty, role-models, Christian formation (implied by Statement of Faith and mission). The explicit “Hiring School Teachers” indicates a teacher-centered approach but lacks a detailed portrait of faculty as “living curriculum” or a formal faculty profile.
- Negative keywords: The public text does not present a strong, explicit “faculty as living curriculum” description or a formal portrait of teacher ideals.
- Quantitative note: 1–2 explicit faculty-related signals; 0 explicit negative signals.
- Why this rating
- Petra demonstrates some alignment with classical expectations through teacher recruitment and theological grounding, but it does not consistently portray the faculty as the living curriculum or as a

tightly defined classical faculty profile. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes tuition-free options and relies on volunteer efforts, signaling meaningful parent involvement and a community approach to governance and financing. This includes recruitment of volunteers to teach, implying a strong community/parental engagement element.
- Admissions materials reference a family application, pastoral references, and parent interviews, indicating active parental involvement in the enrollment process and alignment with the school's mission.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parental engagement, family involvement, home and school connection, parent formation (as implied through family application and pastoral reference processes), parent-teacher collaboration (inferred through volunteer-teacher model).
- Negative keywords: Not evident in public-facing text.
- Quantitative note: Several explicit signals around family involvement and partnerships; 2–4 key phrases/signals identified; no explicit negative signals.
- Why this rating
- Petra shows tangible engagement with families and a community-based model (volunteer teachers, family applications, pastoral involvement) but does not consistently articulate a fully developed classical-education partnership framework (e.g., formal parent-co-teacher strategies, structured classical family formation programs). This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

What Would Move the Needle

If the school aspires to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL, the following concrete steps would be impactful:

- Curriculum clarity and expansion
- Explicitly articulate the curriculum's classical components: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; and Quadrivium as applicable), Great Books program, and the Great Conversation. Include a publicly visible matrix mapping courses to Trivium/Quadrivium phases and the Great Books canon.
- Introduce a Great Books sequence (with primary texts) and a formal Great Conversation initiative for upper grades, with teacher-guided discussion rubrics and assessment anchored in dialectic reasoning. Evidence sources: the Six Essential Elements emphasize Great Books and Great Conversation as core markers of classical education.
- Pedagogical method enhancements
- Integrate explicit SCholé (restful learning) pacing and opportunities for memorization/recitation in early grades, with documented upper-school Socratic dialogue or Harkness-style seminars in line with classical pedagogy. Publish examples of daily or weekly schemata for memory work and Socratic sessions. Evidence sources: the Six Essential Elements outline "Socratic Dialogue," "Scholé," and related pedagogical signs.
- Liturgical/communal practices
- Include explicit, structured liturgical or communal practices (e.g., morning prayers, liturgical rhythm, communal music) as an explicit part of the daily life, with protocols and outcomes. This would address the liturgical/communal dimension of the religious-metaphysical foundation category. Evidence: Positive signals exist in the "Liturgical and Communal Practices" criterion of classical education literature (the Six Essential Elements), and adding explicit practice would strengthen alignment.

- Faculty as living curriculum
- Develop and publish a formal “faculty profile” that describes teacher virtues, professional development, and how faculty embody the school’s classical aims. Clarify how teachers function as mentors and co-learners with students, and highlight exemplary teacher portraits. Evidence: The Six Elements emphasize “the living curriculum” and the portrait of teachers; public materials should align with this.
- Parent and community partnerships
- Expand formal parent-involvement programs (e.g., classical parent study groups, home-school alignment initiatives, parent education about classical education). Formalize “parents as co-educators” language and provide ongoing opportunities for parent engagement beyond volunteering. Evidence: The Six Elements emphasize partnership with families and community involvement.
- Public articulation of the Great Conversation and canon
- Publish a public synopsis of the “Great Books” canon and a rationale for literature choices, including how they connect to the school’s theological commitments. This would satisfy the curriculum criterion and reinforce the “formation” aim through canonical texts.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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